

6.1 Playing Music And Videos

There are so many distributions out there that it is difficult to say which one supports what format of music (MP3, RM, OGG). But suffice to say that support for MP3 is most important.

But unfortunately for us all, MP3 is a proprietary format owned by Fraunhofer IIS. Red Hat stopped MP3 support from version 8.0 onwards, as under the GPL, they could not include a proprietary software along with the distribution. Most freely distributed versions do not have MP3 support, and this can be an issue for many new users. Well, not if you have *Digit* with you! Here we will guide you towards setting up your Linux OS to play your songs and even videos. After you get acquainted with playback of songs, you can even try encoding (creating) songs or ripping audio CDs.

6.1.1 Play MP3s!

We were testing a distribution called Mandriva 2006 (Mandrake is now Mandriva), and were pleasantly surprised to see that it did not throw any tantrums when playing multimedia files. We did not even have to open the file through the player. The files were automatically recognised by the type, and merely clicking on it opened it in the default player—Kaffeine (bundled with KDE). The interface is nice and friendly; nothing seems left out in the functionality area. Impressed were we. As if that were not enough, we came across Xine player, which has some really cool features. A fast forward that looks and behaves like a VCR—fast forward without missing frames: most players fast forward in steps; Xine does it spanning across all frames. So if you can lay your hands on Mandriva 2006, multimedia is never a problem for you.

If you are using Red Hat or Fedora, life has just been kinder to you too. A versatile multimedia player called Xmms is available as a source-rpm format for download. You just need to download and compile it. Voila—your mp3s now work! Xmms can be downloaded from www.xmms.org/download.php.